**A Hooper's Journey: Moving forward amid the struggles**

By Nadeem Patel | 05/17/19

At 6 feet, 7 inches, 195 pounds, Spencer Foley has his legs stretched out on the gray carpeted floor as he leans his back against a red medicine ball. He's playing his fourth straight game of NBA 2k19 with his friends in his family's basement.

Instead of attending classes and taking jump shots with his college basketball teammates at McNeese University, Foley is back home in Chicago. He made the decision to take time off as he deals with injuries that derailed him from his path of playing Division I basketball. However, Foley has dealt with injuries since his high school days, so he is confident he will be back on track to pick up a basketball within a few months.

"Spencer has always been a very determined and strong-willed individual, so it doesn't surprise me that he's not giving up on his dreams," Hector Camacho said. "When you have a dream like that, you're going to see it through until you have closure."

Foley's first true challenge came during his freshman year at Northside College Preparatory High School in Chicago. While some of his teammates were moved up to the sophomore team, he dealt with an elbow injury. Rather than feeling discouraged, Foley proved himself and worked his way up to the next level.

“That was a big deal because that’s what I wanted to do,” Foley said. “By the end of the year, I made the sophomore team, and I think I was the best player on the team.”

During his junior season, Foley became the city’s leading scorer, averaging 29.7 points a game, and transformed into an “electrifying player,” says Camacho. Despite his level of play, the team fell short of its goals after losing the regional game of the state playoffs. He had to make a decision to return to Northside for his final year of high school or go to a school where he had a chance for more exposure.

When he did finally decide to transfer to Uplift Community High School, a school very different from Northside, his teachers, friends and coaches were surprised. Foley was transferring from the top ranked academic school in the state to a school where generally 90 percent of the SAT scores are below expectations according to Illinois Report Card.

“I was happy that he was going after his dream,” Camacho said. “I will never tell someone not to follow their dream. I was more disappointed from the academic standpoint.”

While people around Foley thought he was making a mistake, he felt confident with his decision. The lanky shooting guard with long, skinny limbs knew exactly what he was getting into and so did his teammates.

“Spencer was the missing piece for us,” says Alex Takor, Foley’s former teammate at Uplift. “He made an instant impact with his shooting and ability to space the floor out.”

Uplift went on to win the basketball state championship, and Foley felt a sense of contentment as the last second ran off the clock and sweat poured down his face. Surrounded by his teammates on the center of the court, he touched the plaque trophy and reflected on the time and effort he put into the game he loves. Usually being one of the quieter players on the court, Foley shouted in joy with his teammates this time as the plaque was hoisted into the air.

“Changing schools like I did was tough,” Foley said. “It was all worth it though since I got to play against great competition, and we won state.”

After winning the state championship, Foley decided to go to a prep school before finally getting an offer from Canisius College to play Division I basketball in Buffalo, New York. Unfortunately, Foley had to face injuries his first two years of college, but this was a situation he was familiar with already.

“I’ve always been physically immature, so dealing with injuries is just part of the journey,” Foley said about his thin stature and weight. “That’s also why I decided to go to prep school. It gave me some time to get stronger.”

Foley’s plan to play basketball after high school was initially going as planned as the slender guard filled into his body frame. However, he faced foot injuries and the head coach left Canisius before Foley even arrived.

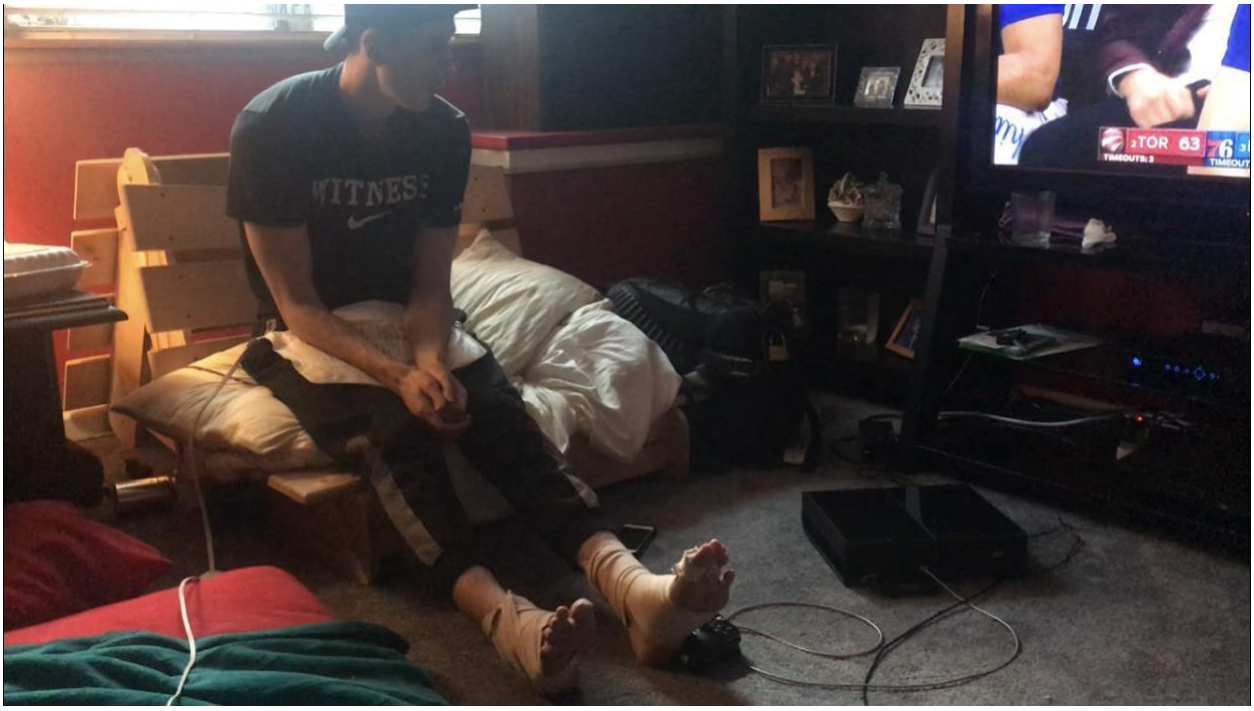
“I wasn’t getting what I needed from Canisius, and I wasn’t healthy enough to even play,” Foley said. “I did what I thought was best for me.”

Hoping for a fresh start, Foley transferred to McNeese State University in Louisiana, but his situation did not get any better. His foot injuries continued, and the unknown severity forced him to be sidelined further. Rather than staying enrolled at McNeese as a redshirt, an athlete who does not participate in the sport for the year, Foley decided to remove himself from school and come home.

McNeese’s coaching staff wanted Foley to continue with workouts and practices while he wanted his redshirt year to be tailored around his recovery.

“College basketball is a business,” Foley said. “It’s much bigger than just you. The way they viewed my redshirt was different to the way I viewed my redshirt. It’s just a tough situation.”

Today, he sits at home as his feet are wrapped in beige cloth tape after having several rounds of platelet-rich plasma and stem cell shots to fasten recovery time of his nagging injuries. As he totters across the room for the remote on the sofa, Foley and his friends begin trash-talking about who is best at NBA 2k19. He simply smiles knowing he had the most wins for the day and switches the channel from the game counsel to watch game four of the Philadelphia 76ers vs Toronto Raptors series. The conversation in the room quickly switches to predictions about who will likely go to the NBA Finals and who are the top players in the league.




Along with the injections and physical therapy Foley is getting, he has also changed his diet and become fully vegan as part of his recovery efforts. He is going through a holistic process to get physically and mentally stronger for his next season. (Photo by Nadeem Patel)

His next goal is to get the attention of mid-major colleges. He feels like a college like Colgate University or even some Division 2 schools might be where he can excel at as a student athlete. With his last two years of eligibility, Foley is hoping to live out his dreams and take them as far as he can.

“I’ve had some good support systems, and people who gave good advice,” Foley said. “I’m taking my destiny in my own hands and control my career. Throughout my life, things haven’t necessarily been controlled by me. I’m 22 years old and I want to take my life and career in my own hands.

Source(s):

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Website(s):

Illinois Report Card, Uplift Community High School, May, 05, 2019, https://www.illinoisreportcard.com/school.aspx?source=studentcharacteristics&Schoolid=150162990250829